

Con-vergence



Illustration Blnesh Shreedharan

The era of digital convergence is not without its misgivings

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Every technology and standard has its drawbacks, its loopholes. Though convergence isn't a technology by itself, it is the process of amalgamation of others, and as a result, the new technologies inherit the same problems that plagued the parent technologies.

In this section, we spell out a few warnings for manufacturers and users alike, and pose a few questions that don't really have an answer right now.



A Matter Of Choice

Technology was always meant to ease our lives, and it did; until now, that is. The problems really begin when you decide to purchase a gadget.

Take the example of a mobile phone—you decide you need a new one. You even set yourself a budget and think, "I'll just buy the best phone available in this price range." Well, good luck finding one—you'll be hit in the face with over 200 models, each boasting one little thing or another that the other models don't have.

Let's assume you're loyal to a few manufacturer brands. So you decide it has to be from your favourite brand. You manage to whittle the choices down to less than 20. Of course, every dealer out there has his 'favourites'—the phones he gets the most profit out of—and will try and sell you everything but what you want.

The days when dealers sold phones by the kilo are long gone, too. Every second dealer reads up on phones now.

Of the 20 phones available from your favourite brand, about 10 will be out of your budget—and teasingly so. You'll be tempted to spend that little extra. You'll read the features list and drool—Bluetooth, GPRS, 3G, PIM Applications, Java-enabled, games, PDA Applications, multi-megapixel video cameras, MP3 support—ad infinitum, ad nauseam.

The accepted practice today is to buy a phone with features you'll never use! Why? Because mobile phones are so common today that you need to have that something extra just to be able to maintain your identity in your circle of acquaintances!

The convergence of a whole lot of technologies into everyday devices is making it harder for us